overwhelmingly superior Mughal forces, in addition to gritty resistance from splinter Ahmadnagar groups led by generals of genius such as Malik Ambar, that ‘passive resistance through diplomacy’ was the most prudent path for him. There were those, such as the Flemish jeweller Jacques de Coutre, who found himself at the Bijapur court at this time, who were scathing about Ibrahim’s strategy. Coutre referred to him as ‘a coward, tyrant, arbitrary, and obsessed with his harem of over 900 concubines “who served him carnally when he wished”’. When Akbar finally grew frustrated at Mir Jamal-ud Din’s inability to resolve the matter, he sent Abu’l Fazl’s officer and friend, Asad Beg, to get to the truth of the matter. The truth, it turned out, was money, for Asad Beg found out that Mir Jamal ud-Din was making some ‘300,000 or 400,000 huns’ of money which corresponded to a jagir of 5,000, and that even Akbar’s trusted courtier Abdur Rahim was receiving sums of money to delay matters. Akbar had instructed Asad Beg to bring back the mir without even ‘giving him a chance to take a sip of water’.

Before Asad Beg arrived in Bijapur, however, he met with a personage who was recognized as someone whose support should be cultivated—Malik Ambar. The Mughals gifted an elephant and a fine horse to the Ethiopian general as well as a farman from Akbar. Malik Ambar, it was said, was looking for patronage and was eager to serve the Mughal emperor. In fact, wrote Asad Beg approvingly, ‘Ambar was the paragon of all good qualities, a wonderful host, and a devout Muslim. Indeed, were he to recount the qualities of this bravest of the men of the time, a chapter—nay, a book—would be needed.’ Relations, at this time at least, were entirely cordial between Malik Ambar and the Mughals.* After feting the Mughal envoy with suitably grand festivities, Malik Ambar sent his young nephew to accompany Asad Beg as he headed south towards Bijapur.

When Asad Beg arrived in Bijapur, he discovered a prosperous, thriving city. The bazaars impressed the Mughal envoy with their variety of exquisite goods. He wrote of jeweller’s shops with daggers, knives, mirrors, and necklaces all in the shapes of birds studded with jewels. There were liquor shops filled with crystal bottles and china vessels. There were fruit shops groaning with ‘fruits and sweetmeats, relishes, sugar-candy and almonds’. The bazaar was spotlessly clean, a long boulevard lined with green trees. He described even more enchanting enticements next to the bazaar: